Colon Cancer

Patient and Family Education Booklet

Dana-Farber
Cancer Institute

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ABOUT THIS HANDBOOK

This booklet is a guide for patients and families who are dealing with a new colon cancer diagnosis. It shares clear medical information and helpful tips.

The booklet will help you learn:

- What colon cancer is
- How doctors find colon cancer
- How colon cancer is treated
- What side effects may happen during treatment
- How to help with side effects
- When to call your medical team
- What happens after treatment

Read this booklet with your family. If you do not understand something, ask your doctor or nurse. You do not have to go through this alone. Your healthcare team is here to help you.

ABOUT COLON CANCER

WHAT IS CANCER?

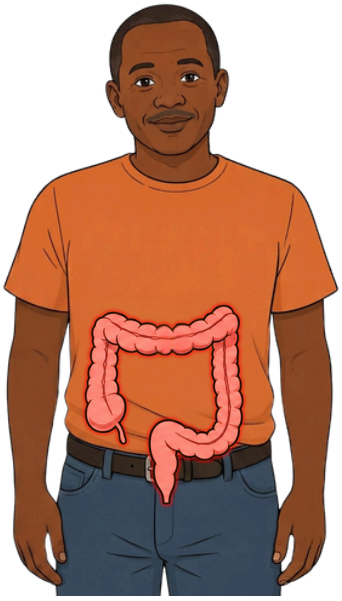
Cancer is a group of diseases. It happens when some cells in a person's body grow too fast and do not stop. Cancer can start in many parts of the body. Where it starts can change how a person feels and how doctors treat the cancer. Cancer can also spread to other parts of the body if it is not treated.

WHAT ARE COMMON MYTHS ABOUT CANCER?

- Cancer is not something you can catch, like a cold. Cancer does not spread from person to person through touching, hugging, sharing food, or living together.
- Cancer is not caused by a witch doctor or a curse.
- Cancer is not a punishment for something a person did. It simply occurs in some people for reasons that are not well understood.
- Cancer does not only occur in rich people. Cancer can develop in anyone, young or old, rich or poor, male or female.
- Cancer is not always fatal. Each person's experience with cancer will be different. Everyone with cancer has a different chance of survival.

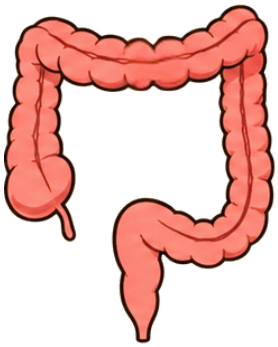
WHAT IS COLON CANCER?

The **colon** is part of the digestive system. It is like a long tube that helps you digest food and remove water from food waste. It is also called the large intestine. The end of the large intestine is called the **rectum**.

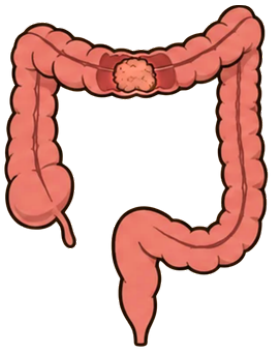


The colon is inside your stomach area.

Colon cancer starts when cells on the inside of the colon stop acting like normal cells. These cells grow and divide fast. This makes a lump of cancer cells called a **tumor**. Over time, the cancer can start to spread outside your colon to other parts of the body.



A healthy colon.



A colon with cancer.

Doctors do not always know why a person gets colon cancer. Some things can raise the risk. A person's age, genes, lifestyle, and environment might increase a person's chance of getting colon cancer. Colon cancer can happen in both men and women.

WHAT ARE SIGNS AND SYMPTOMS OF COLON CANCER?

Some people have no symptoms at first. As the cancer grows, common symptoms include:

- Diarrhea or constipation
- Bright red or very dark blood in your stool
- Constant belly pain, bloating, or feeling like your bowel does not empty fully
- Feeling very tired or weak
- Losing weight without trying

These symptoms can also be caused by other illnesses, but you should be seen by a health care clinician to be sure.

DIAGNOSING AND STAGING COLON CANCER

WHAT IS DIAGNOSIS?

A diagnosis tells us that you have cancer and what type of cancer it is. A **biopsy** is a test that is used to make the diagnosis.

WHAT IS STAGING?

Staging is a word used to describe how much cancer is in the body. Staging helps doctors choose the best treatment. Different tests are used to learn where the cancer is and how far it has spread.

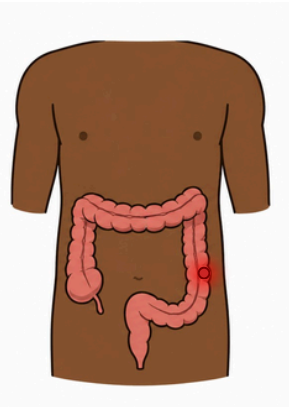
Cancer is often staged from 1 to 4. When the cancer is only in one place in the body, this is called stage 1. In stage 4, the cancer has spread to other parts of the body. When this happens, the cancer is **metastatic**.

WHAT ARE THE STAGES OF COLON CANCER?

Colon cancer has 4 main stages. Your doctor will explain the stage of your cancer and your treatment plan.

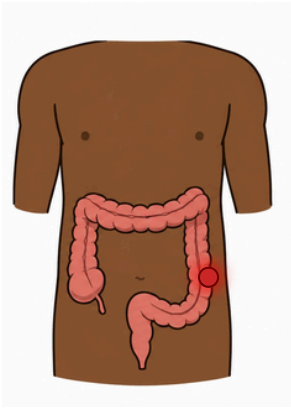
Stage 1

Cancer is only on the inside wall of the colon.



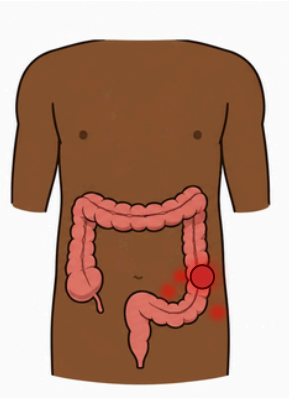
Stage 2

Cancer has grown deeper into the wall of the colon.



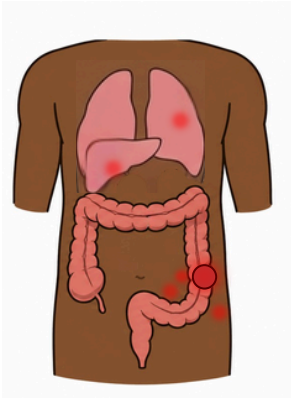
Stage 3

Cancer has spread to nearby areas or lymph nodes, part of the body's immune system.



Stage 4

Cancer has spread to distant parts of the body, like the liver or lungs.

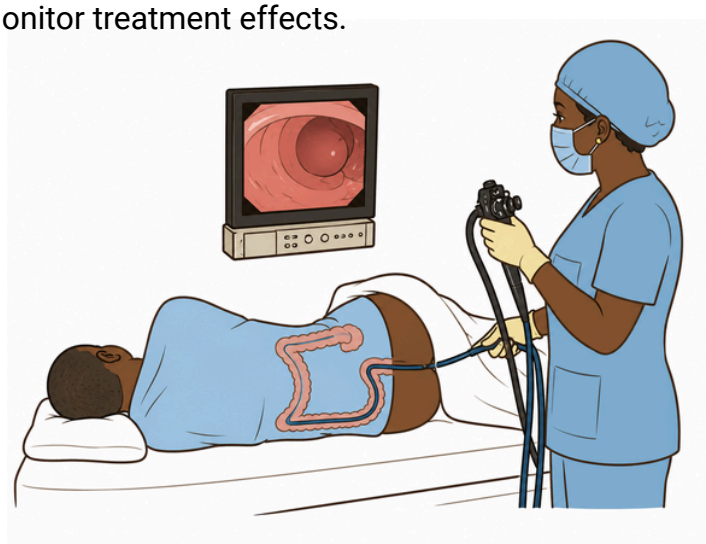


WHAT TESTS AND PROCEDURES WILL I HAVE?

Your doctor will order some tests and procedures to better understand what is happening in your body and how to help you. These tests might be done before starting treatment to help stage the cancer, or during treatment to monitor treatment effects.

Colonoscopy

A colonoscopy is a test where a small, soft tube with a camera is put into your rectum and colon. You will lie on your side or your back. The doctor will guide the tube through your colon and use the camera to look inside. This test is important to help the doctor see the tumor and take small pieces of tissue for testing.



A doctor looks inside the colon during a colonoscopy.

The day before your colonoscopy, you can only drink clear liquids like water and broth. You will also take medicine to clean out your colon. During the procedure, you might be given medicine to help you relax and sleep. The procedure usually takes about 30 to 60 minutes.

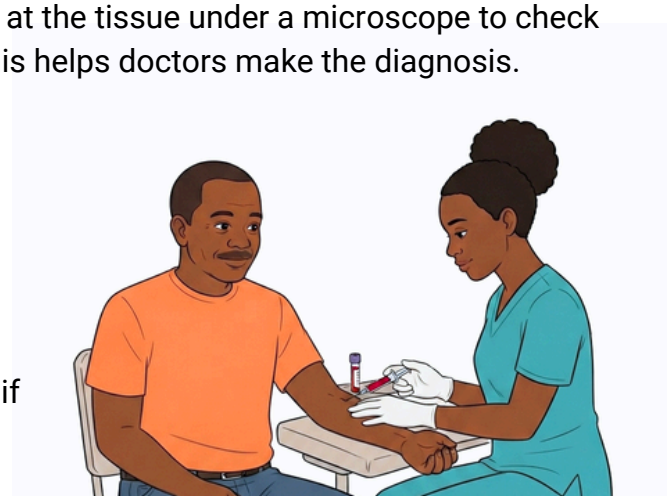
A doctor looks at cells in the lab.

Biopsy

A biopsy is a test where the doctor takes a small piece of tissue or cells from the body to check for cancer. The tissue might be collected during a colonoscopy. A doctor at the laboratory will look at the tissue under a microscope to check for cancer cells. This helps doctors make the diagnosis.

Blood test

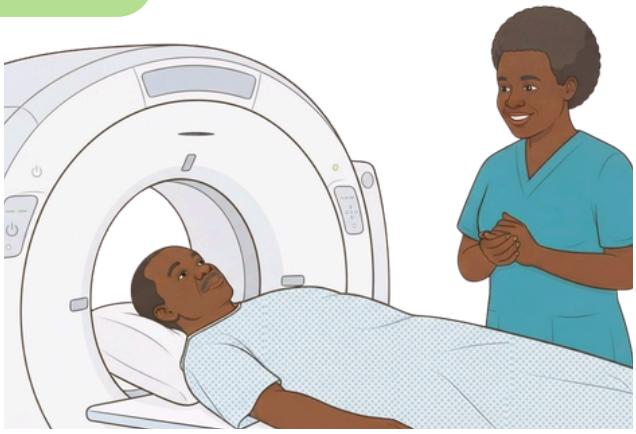
Blood tests may be done many times during your treatment. The nurse will use a needle to take a small amount of blood. The blood test will check if your kidneys and liver are working properly and if your blood counts are normal. This is especially important before and after receiving chemotherapy.



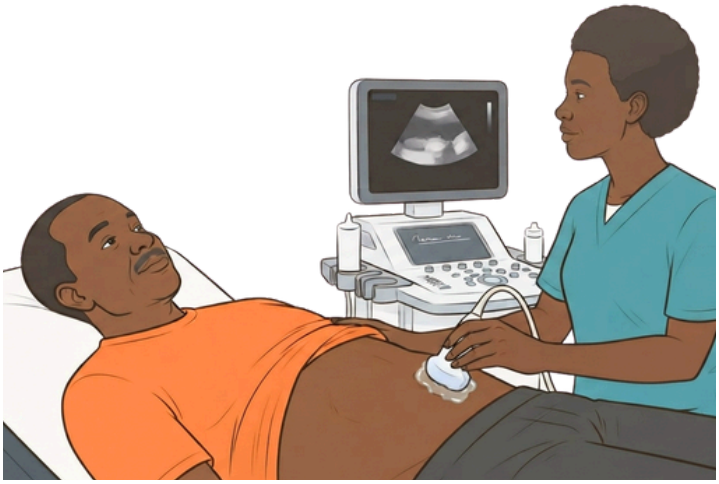
A nurse draws blood for a blood test.

Computerized Axial Tomography (CAT) Scan

The CAT scan takes pictures of the inside of your body. This helps doctors see if the cancer has spread to other parts of your body. During the scan, you will lie still on a table that moves slowly through a large machine. The scan does not hurt, but you will have to be perfectly still while the pictures are being taken. It usually takes about 15 to 30 minutes.



The patient lies still while the CAT scan machine takes pictures.



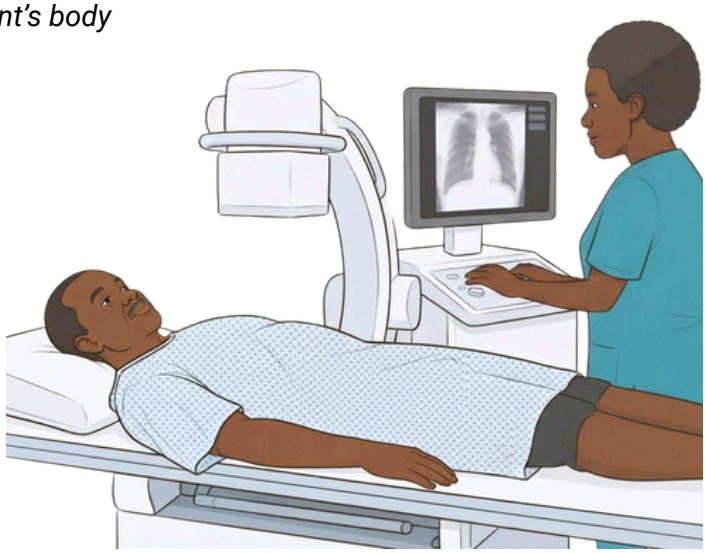
A nurse puts the ultrasound device on the patient's body to get a picture.

Ultrasound

This is a test that uses a handheld device to get a picture of what is happening inside the body. This helps the doctor know if the cancer has spread. The person doing the test will put gel on part of your body to help get a better picture. This procedure is not painful.

X-Ray

This is a test that uses a special camera to take a picture of the inside of your body. You will stand or lie still while a machine takes the picture. X-rays are often used to check your lungs. The test only takes a few minutes and does not hurt.



An X-Ray technician uses the X-Ray machine.

TREATING COLON CANCER

Your doctor will make a treatment plan for you. Your treatment plan will depend on the size of the cancer and whether it has spread to other parts of your body. You might have **surgery**, **chemotherapy**, or a combination of both.

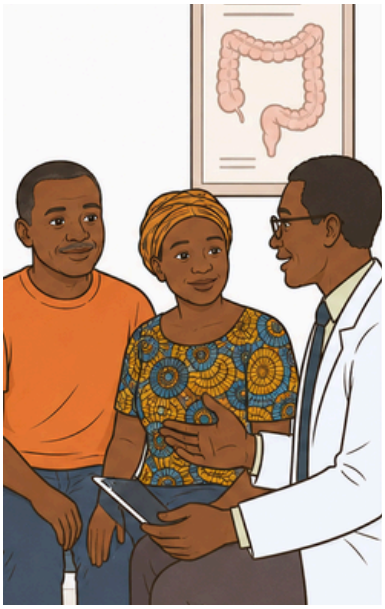
WHAT IS SURGERY?

Surgery is usually the main treatment for colon cancer. The goal of surgery is to remove as much of the cancer from your body as possible. The way the doctor does this will depend on where the tumor is and how big it is. Your doctor will tell you how to prepare before surgery.

During surgery, a trained doctor called a surgeon will remove the part of the colon that has cancer. This is called a **colectomy**. You will be given medicine to make you sleep during the surgery so you do not feel pain.

Meeting with the care team before the surgery.

Doctors perform the surgery.



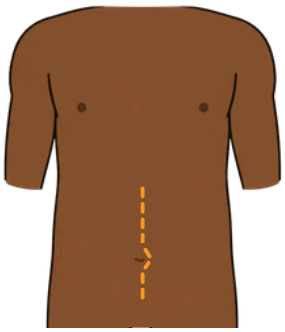
Meeting with the care team after the surgery.

After surgery, you will stay in the hospital for several days. Your care team will help you recover. They will discuss the different types of treatment that may take place after surgery, like **physiotherapy**, which will help you regain your movement and strength.

You will have a wound where the surgeon made the cut. Your care team will show you how to care for your wound at home. They will also tell you what foods are best to eat while your colon is recovering.

WHAT IS A COLECTOMY?

The surgery for colon cancer is called a **colectomy**. During a colectomy, the surgeon will make a cut in your stomach to reach the colon. The length and direction of the cut will depend on where the cancer is.



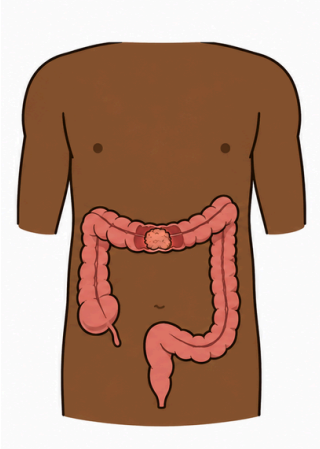
The surgeon will make a cut in the stomach.

Then the surgeon will remove the part of the colon that has cancer. The amount of colon removed will depend on the size and location of the cancer.

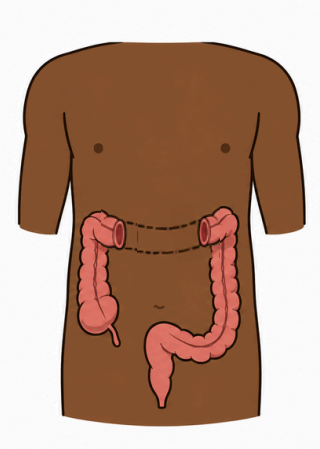
The surgeon may also remove some of the lymph nodes around the cancer. **Lymph nodes** are small glands that are part of your immune system. Removing them helps the doctor check if the cancer has spread beyond the colon.

After removing the section of colon with cancer, the surgeon will join the two healthy ends of the colon back together. This will allow waste to continue to pass through your colon as normal.

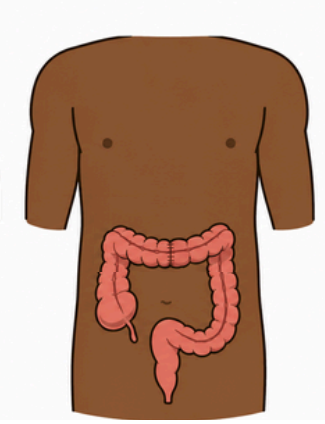
In some cases, the surgeon may not be able to join the colon back together right away. In this case, you may need a **colostomy**.



Cancer grows inside the colon.



The surgeon removes the part of the colon with cancer.

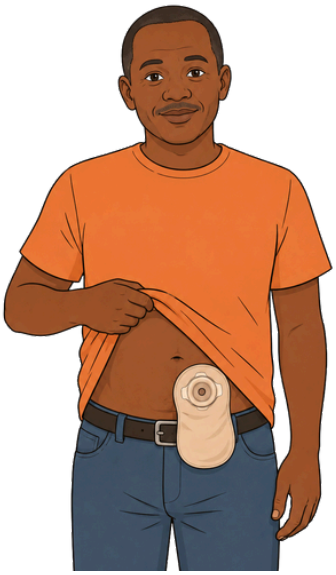


The surgeon joins the colon back together.

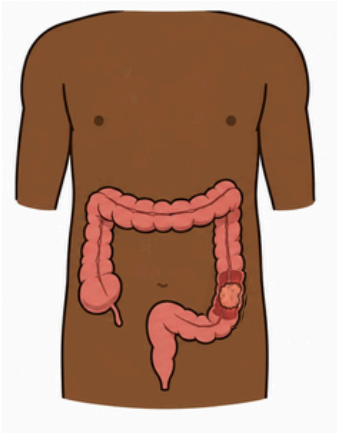
WHAT IS A COLOSTOMY?

A colostomy is when the surgeon makes a small opening in your stomach called a **stoma**. The surgeon will connect your colon to this opening. Waste from your body will leave through this opening into a small bag on the outside of your body, instead of passing through your rectum. This bag is called a **colostomy bag**.

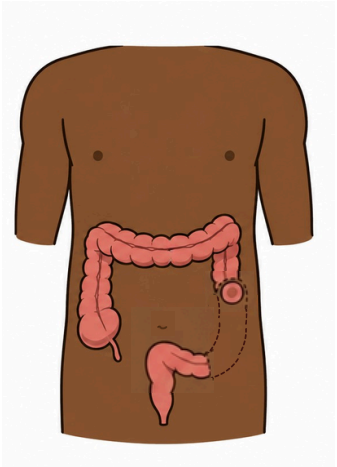
For some patients, the colostomy is temporary. The opening will be closed after your colon has healed. For other patients, the colostomy may be permanent. Your doctor will tell you if you need a colostomy and whether it will be temporary or permanent.



A patient with a colostomy bag after surgery.



Cancer grows inside the colon.



The surgeon removes the part of the colon with cancer, leaving a stoma.

The surgeon connects the stoma to a colostomy bag instead of joining the colon back together.

Getting used to a colostomy bag can be hard at first. You will have to learn how to clean your stoma and change the colostomy bag. Your care team will teach you how to care for your stoma and your colostomy bag.

It is normal to have difficult feelings about a colostomy. Many patients feel sad or worried about how their body looks and feels after surgery. It may take some time to be comfortable with the changes in your body. There are many people you can talk to about how you are feeling, like social workers, psychologists, your nurse or doctor, or other patients. Talking to others about the changes you are going through can help.

WHAT IS CHEMOTHERAPY?

Chemotherapy is a medicine that kills cancer cells or stops them from growing. Chemotherapy can be used before surgery to shrink the tumor, after surgery to kill any cancer cells that may be left, or when the cancer has spread to other parts of the body.

Chemotherapy medicine is usually given through a needle into your vein. This is called an intravenous infusion, or an **IV**. You will sit or lie down while the medicine drips slowly into your vein through a small tube.

Other chemotherapy medicines come as pills that you swallow.

The patient takes chemotherapy medicine by mouth.

A nurse gives the patient chemotherapy through an IV.

You will receive chemotherapy in **cycles**. A cycle is one round of chemo. It has two parts: treatment days and rest days. Treatment days are when you receive chemotherapy. After treatment days, you will have some rest days or weeks to allow your body to recover. Then the cycle starts over again. Your doctor will let you know how many treatment days and rest days are in your cycle, and how many cycles you will have in total.

It is very important that you do not become pregnant or get someone pregnant while taking chemotherapy.

It is okay to have sexual relations during and after your colon cancer treatment. However, it is important to use family planning to prevent pregnancy and protect your partner. You may need to continue using contraception for several months after treatment. Talk with your healthcare team about the methods of family planning that are best for you.

WHAT CHEMOTHERAPY MEDICINES WILL I RECEIVE?

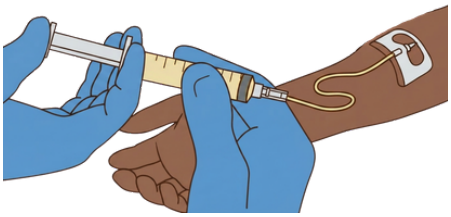
5-Fluorouracil (5-FU), capecitabine, **ironotecan**, and **oxaliplatin** are common chemotherapy medicines that treat colon cancer. You may also take a medicine called **leucovorin**. You might take a combination of these medicines together. This is called a **regimen**.

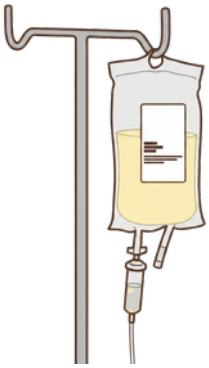
5-Fluorouracil (5-FU)

5-Fluorouracil is also called 5-FU. It is given through an IV. A nurse will use a syringe to give you 5-FU through your IV, or you will sit down while medicine drips slowly into your vein.

Common side effects of 5-FU may include but are not limited to:

- Nausea & vomiting
- Diarrhea
- Low blood counts
- Hair loss
- Mouth sores
- Hand-foot syndrome





Capecitabine

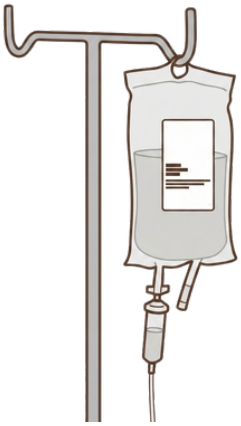
Capecitabine is given as a pill. You will take the pill according to your doctor's instructions.

Common side effects of capecitabine may include but are not limited to:

- Nausea & vomiting
- Low blood counts
- Hand-foot syndrome
- Diarrhea
- Mouth sores

Irinotecan

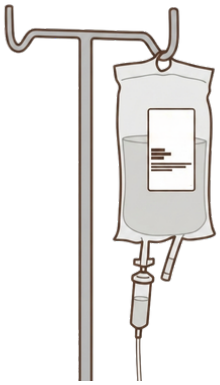
Irinotecan is given through an IV. You will sit or lie down while medicine drips slowly into your vein from a bag.



Common side effects of irinotecan may include but are not limited to:

- Diarrhea
- Nausea & vomiting
- Low blood counts
- Constipation
- Hair loss
- Mouth sores

Oxaliplatin

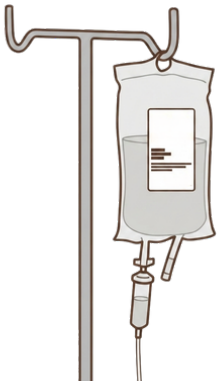


Oxaliplatin is given through an IV. You will sit or lie down while medicine drips slowly into your vein from a bag.

Common side effects of oxaliplatin are:

- Sensitivity to the cold
- Peripheral neuropathy (numbness or tingling in hands and feet)
- Nausea & vomiting
- Diarrhea
- Constipation

Leucovorin



Leucovorin is also called **folinic acid**. It is given through an IV. You will sit or lie down while medicine drips slowly into your vein from a bag.

Common side effects of leucovorin are:

- Skin rash, dryness or itching
- Mouth sores and diarrhea (when taken with florouracil)

WHAT IS A CHEMOTHERAPY REGIMEN?

A regimen is when the doctor gives you a combination of chemotherapy medicines together. These regimens have different names. You might take a combination regimen called **FOLFOX** or **CAPEOX**.

		FOL	F	OX
FOLFOX	→	Leucovorin (folinic acid)	5-Fluorouracil	Oxaliplatin

When leucovorin, 5-fluorouracil, and oxaliplatin are given together, the regimen is called FOLFOX.

		CAPE	OX
CAPEOX	→	Capecitabine	Oxaliplatin

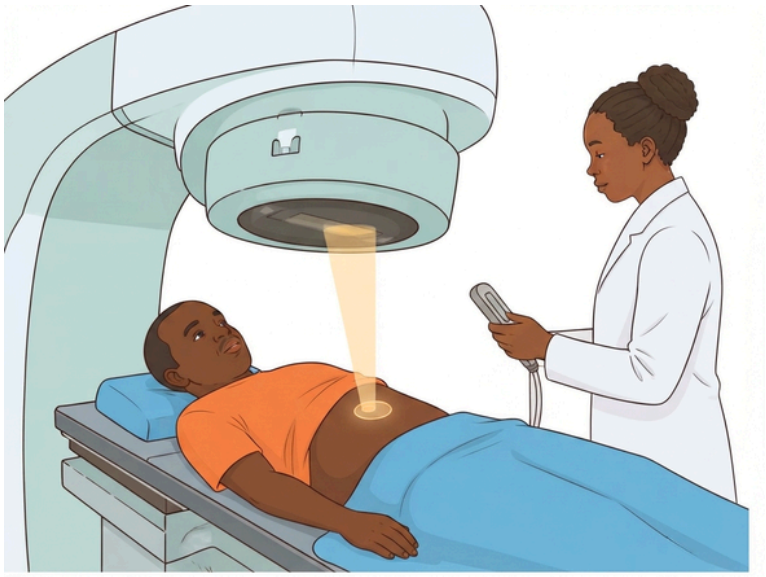
When capecitabine and oxaliplatin are given together, the regimen is called CAPEOX.

WHAT IS RADIATION?

Radiation therapy is not usually used for colon cancer. It will only be used in a few cases.

Radiation uses strong energy to kill cancer cells. Receiving radiation therapy is like having an X-Ray. You won't see or feel anything, but you must lie as still as possible for a few minutes. A machine will point energy at the cancer in your body while you lie still. Each session usually takes about 15 to 30 minutes. You will have many sessions over several weeks.

Radiation does not make you radioactive. It is safe to be around other people, including children, after your treatment.



The patient lies still during radiation therapy.

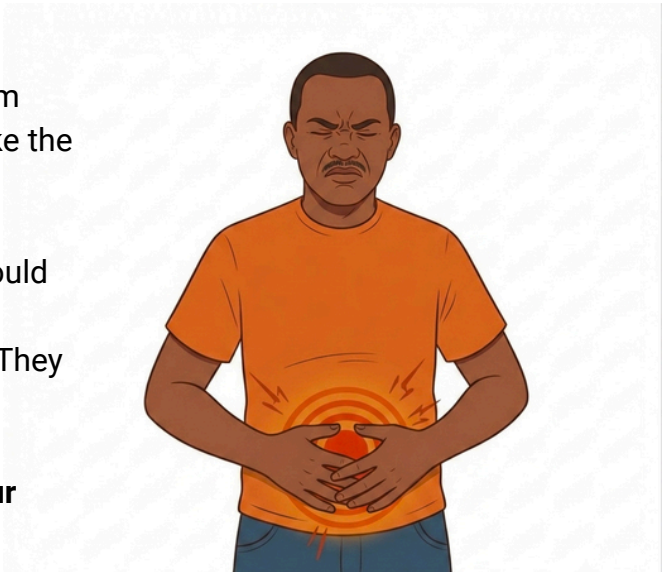
SIDE EFFECTS OF TREATMENT

Surgery, chemotherapy, and radiation therapy may each cause side effects. Some side effects are common and can be managed at home. Talk to your healthcare team if you are having a hard time with side effects. They can help you find ways to manage side effects and get through treatment safely.

Although these side effects are the most common, you may experience other side effects due to treatment that are not shown here. Tell your healthcare team if you do not feel well. They can figure out if this is a side effect of treatment or if you are having another illness.

WHAT ARE COMMON SIDE EFFECTS OF SURGERY?

Pain



It is normal to feel pain after surgery. Your care team will give you medicine to help manage the pain. Take the medicine exactly as prescribed by the doctor.

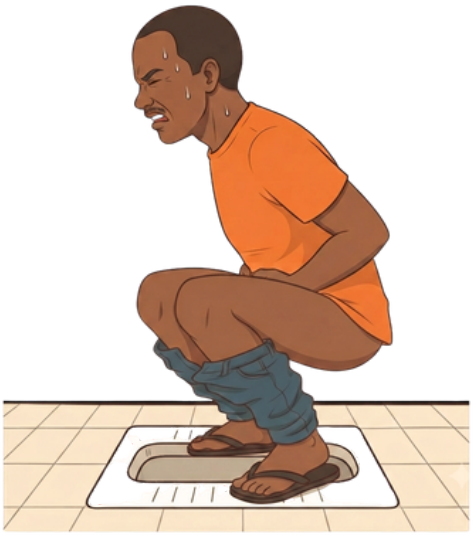
Your pain may not go away completely. But you should be able to sleep, walk, and do daily activities. **If you cannot do these things, tell your healthcare team**. They can give you stronger medicine.

If the pain is very bad or not getting better, call your doctor or nurse right away.

Fatigue

It is normal to feel very tired after surgery. Rest as much as you need to. Get plenty of sleep and do light activities when you can. Your strength will come back over time.

Constipation



You may be constipated after surgery. Drink plenty of fluids (water, juice, milk, or soup). Eat soft and simple foods like fruits and cooked vegetables. Talk to your healthcare team about what foods you should eat after surgery.

Take anti-constipation medications as prescribed by the doctor. **If you have not had a bowel movement in two days and anti-constipation medicine does not help, call your doctor or nurse.**

Diarrhea

You may have diarrhea after surgery. Drink plenty of fluids (water, juice, milk, or soup) to prevent dehydration. Eat simple foods like bananas and rice. Talk to your healthcare team about what foods you should eat after surgery.

Take anti-diarrhea medications as prescribed by the doctor. **If you have diarrhea that lasts more than 3 days and anti-diarrhea medicine does not help, call your doctor or nurse.**

Infection

It usually takes about 2 to 3 weeks for the skin to heal after surgery. Until the skin is healed, you are at higher risk for infection. Check your wound every day and keep the area clean and dry.

The nurses and doctor will examine this area closely. Call them right away if you see any of these signs of infection:

- **Redness**
- **Swelling**
- **Warmth**
- **Fluid coming from the wound**

WHAT ARE COMMON SIDE EFFECTS OF CHEMOTHERAPY?

Nausea & Vomiting

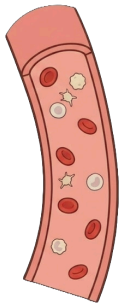
Feeling sick and vomiting can make you not want to eat, become dehydrated, and have low energy. Try to prevent nausea by taking anti-nausea medication as prescribed by the doctor. Make sure you drink plenty of water. Eat small meals throughout the day with bland food. Avoid spicy or greasy foods.

Fatigue

You may feel very tired during chemotherapy. This is a normal side effect and can get worse over time. It is important to get good sleep and rest during treatment. Try to do light exercise. Even walking for 20 minutes a day can help.

Hair Loss

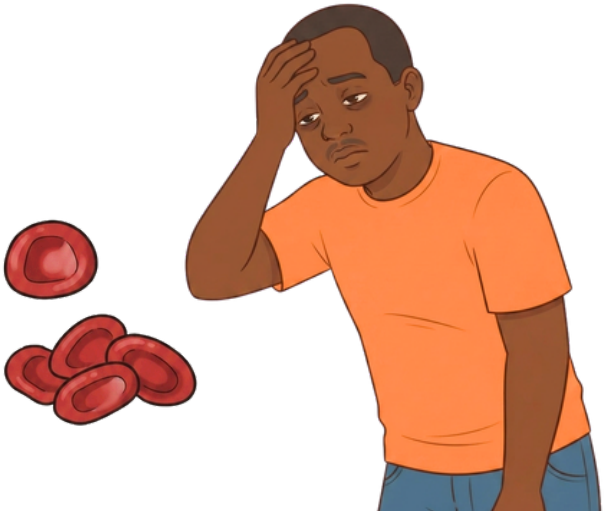
Your hair will fall out during chemotherapy treatment. Be careful to protect your head from the sun or the cold by wearing a hat or scarf when going outside. Your hair will grow back when your treatment is finished.



Low Blood Counts

Chemotherapy can lower the number of blood cells in your body. This can make you more likely to get infections, feel very tired, or bleed easily. Your doctor will check your blood regularly during treatment.

Red blood cells carry oxygen and give you energy. You may be more tired and get short of breath easily.



White blood cells fight infection in your body. You may be at risk for infection and fever. **If you have a fever or chills, call the doctor or nurse right away.**

Platelets help stop bleeding. You may bleed or get bruised more easily. Be careful to avoid getting injured.

If you have blood in the urine or stool, bruises, or blood from the mouth or nose, call the doctor or nurse right away.

Constipation

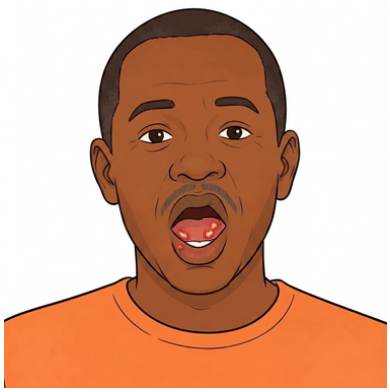
Some chemotherapy may cause constipation. Drink plenty of fluids (water, juice, milk, or soup). Eat soft and simple foods like fruits and cooked vegetables. Take anti-constipation medications as prescribed by the doctor.

If you do not have a bowel movement in 2 days and anti-diarrhea medicine does not help, call your doctor or nurse.

Diarrhea

Some chemotherapy may cause diarrhea. Drink plenty of fluids (water, juice, milk, or soup) to prevent dehydration. Eat simple foods like bananas and rice. Take anti-diarrhea medications as prescribed by the doctor.

If you have diarrhea that lasts more than 3 days and anti-diarrhea medicine does not help, call your doctor or nurse.



Mouth Sores

Some chemotherapy may cause sores in your mouth. These sores can also be found on the lips and the throat. Make sure that your mouth is clean and that you use mouth rinses prescribed by the doctor. **If the mouth sores become painful and prevent you from eating, ask your doctor for pain medication.**

Hand-Foot Syndrome

Chemotherapy may cause pain, swelling, and peeling on the palms of your hands or the soles of your feet. Heat and pressure can make this worse: avoid hot baths, tight shoes, and heavy exercise that causes rubbing. Dry your skin gently, do not rub. Applying a thick, scent-free lotion to your hands and feet can help. You may need pain medications if these symptoms become severe.

Peripheral Neuropathy

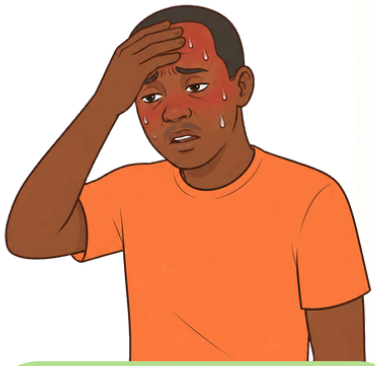
Tell your healthcare team if you have a burning pain or numbness in your fingers or toes. This is called peripheral neuropathy. They may change your treatment medications or give you a pain reliever to help these symptoms. Pain or numbness can last for many years after treatment.

Infertility

Some chemotherapy may affect your ability to have children. Tell your healthcare team before treatment starts if you are worried about this. They will talk to you about how to navigate this.

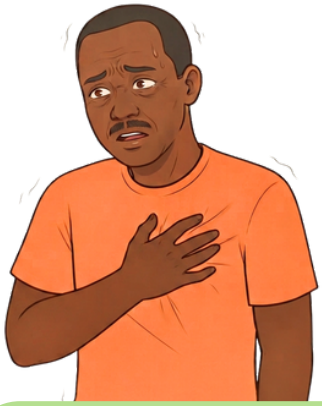
WHEN TO CALL YOUR MEDICAL TEAM

Call your care team or go to the nearest health center if:



You have a fever, chills, or feel hot to touch

You have vomiting that does not stop

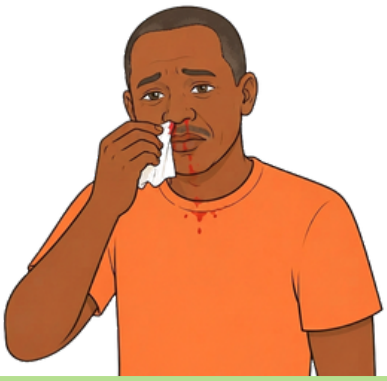


You are short of breath, dizzy, or especially tired

You have constipation with no bowel movement in 2 days

You have diarrhea 3 or more times a day

You have blood in urine or stool



You have bleeding that does not stop after 15 minutes of gentle pressure

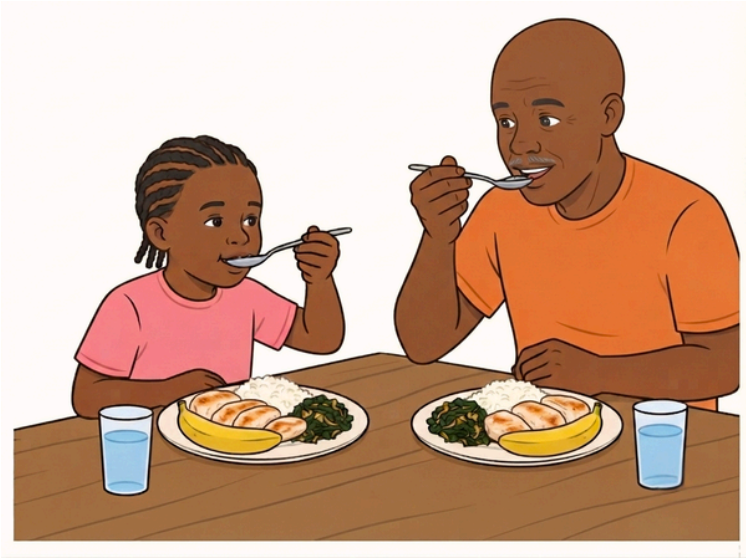
You have severe pain and pain medicine does not help

GETTING THROUGH TREATMENT

These are some simple ways for you to help yourself get through treatment safely. Your family can also help you with these things. During treatment, especially after surgery, it is normal to have trouble with your energy levels, your appetite, and your bowel movements. Remember to talk to your care team about any concerns that you have.

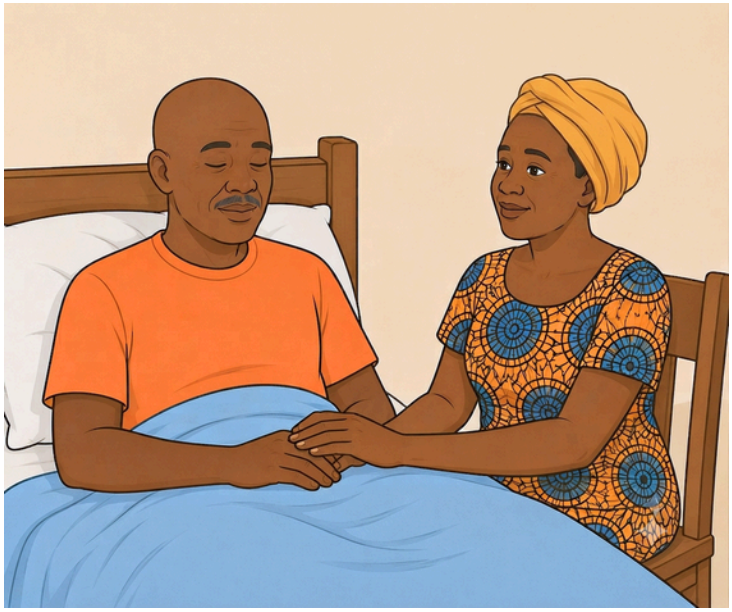
Eat well

Try to eat small meals throughout the day. Choose soft, easy-to-digest foods while you get used to the changes in your colon. Talk to your care team about the foods that are best for you to eat.



Rest when you feel tired

Try to rest and take naps. Do light activities and movement when you can. Do not push yourself to work or do activities when you do not have enough energy.



Drink lots of water

Staying hydrated will help your body recover. Drink small sips of water often throughout the day.

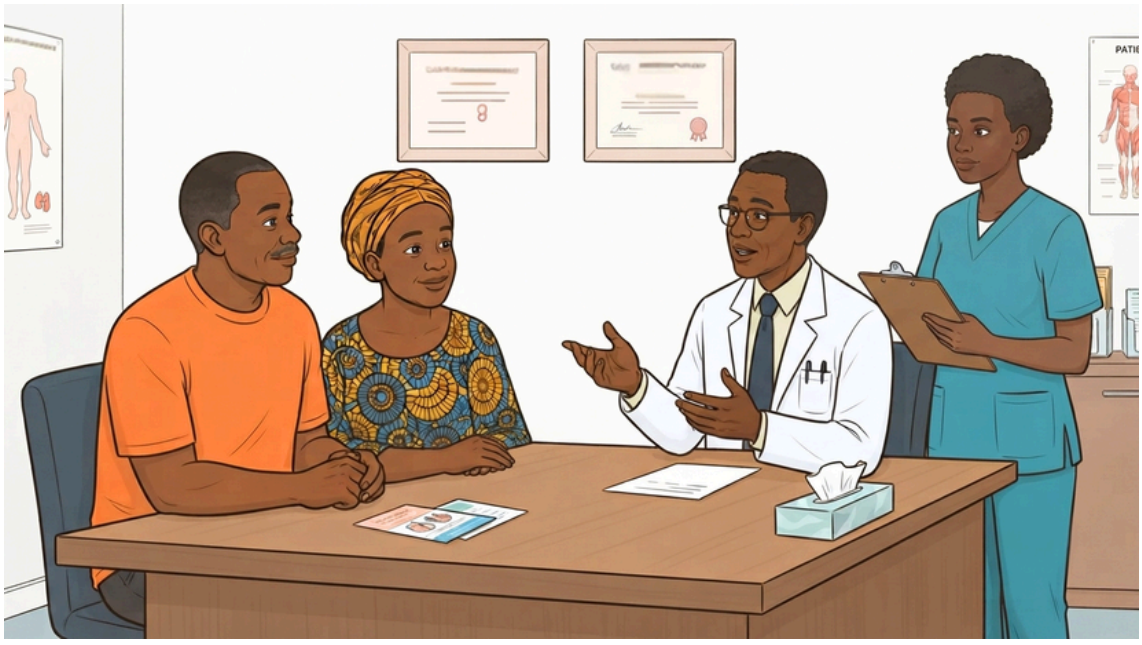
Take your medications as prescribed

It is very important to take your medications at the right times and in the right amounts. Talk to your care team if you are having problems taking your medicine.

FOLLOW-UP CARE

After all treatment is finished, you will have regular follow-up appointments with your healthcare team. This is to make sure that your cancer is not coming back and that the side effects of treatment are under control.

It is important to come to every follow-up appointment with your healthcare team.



Meeting with the care team at a follow-up appointment.

QUESTIONS TO ASK YOUR MEDICAL TEAM

These are some questions you can ask to better understand your cancer and treatment plan. If you or your family have any other questions, don't hesitate to ask your care team.

- What stage is my colon cancer?
- What treatment will I need?
- If I am receiving surgery, how should I prepare?
- If I am receiving surgery, will I need a colostomy?
- What side effects should I expect?
- What foods and drinks are best for me to eat?
- What medicines will I take at home?
- When can I go back to daily activities like work or caring for my family?
- Who can I call if I have more questions?

NOTES

IMPORTANT PHONE NUMBERS

REFERENCES

www.bowelcanceraustralia.org
www.dana-farber.org/cancer-care/types/colon-cancer